sector, which includes the Shipki La and Bara Hoti plateau in the UP-Tibet border area. We should be prepared for a long haul as far as these negotiations are concerned, as I did not think the Chinese appeared to be in a hurry to resolve the problem. This being my first visit to China, it was a great experience to see the Forbidden City, the Great Wall and the shopping malls of Beijing. To top it all, the hosts took us out for traditional Chinese cuisine, including the Peking duck.

During 1998, I also participated in the inconclusive Indo-Pak dialogue on issues like Siachen, Sir Creek, sharing of river waters – all this when the infamous Operation 'Badr' in Kargil was perhaps being planned by Pakistan. We maintained our stand that the first step to resolve the Siachen problem should be the authentication of the existing positions of both sides. Besides, we brought out that the issue in question should thereafter be the pull-back from the Saltoro range by the two armies. To call it the 'Siachen issue' is a misnomer as the Siachen glacier is well to the east of the Saltoro range, along which lies the actual ground position line (AGPL).